

How to Explain Fibromyalgia to Family Who Don't Believe You

Practical NHS-backed advice on how to explain fibromyalgia to family who don't believe you.

By **Living With Arthritis UK** · Reviewed by **Louis Maxwell** (HCPC Registered Physiotherapist) · 2026-07-24 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

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Quick Answer: This guide provides evidence-based, practical advice on how to explain fibromyalgia to family who don't believe you — drawing on NHS guidance, NICE guidelines, and UK charity resources to help you get the support you need.

Whether you're newly facing this question or looking to deepen your understanding, this guide gives you key information clearly explained, with signposting to the best free UK resources.

Understanding Your Options

When it comes to how to explain fibromyalgia to family who don't believe you, knowing what is available to you is the essential first step. Many people are unaware of the free services and legal entitlements that exist specifically for people with arthritis and related conditions in the UK.

What UK Resources Are Available



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The UK has a comprehensive network of support including NHS services, charitable organisations, financial benefits, and community resources. Most people can access more support than they initially realise.

Key Support Points

- Versus Arthritis helpline: 0800 5200 520 (free, Mon–Fri)
- Citizens Advice: 0800 144 8848 for benefits and rights
- NRAS (RA specific): 0800 298 7650
- NHS services including physiotherapy available via GP referral
- Living With Arthritis UK: livingwitharthritis.org.uk

Practical Next Steps

Start by contacting your GP to ensure your condition is properly documented and to explore referral options. Keep a symptom diary noting which activities are most affected — this is valuable both for medical appointments and any benefit assessments. Connect with the relevant condition-specific charity for tailored guidance and peer support.

Your Rights and Entitlements



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Arthritis is recognised as a disability under the Equality Act 2010 if it has a substantial, long-term effect on your daily activities. This gives you legal protections at work, the right to reasonable adjustments, and may entitle you to financial benefits including PIP or Attendance Allowance depending on your circumstances.

Looking After Your Wellbeing

Living with a long-term condition affects mental health as well as physical health. Depression and anxiety are significantly more common in people with arthritis. Don't hesitate to discuss mental health support with your GP — talking therapies and peer support are both effective and available on the NHS.

Q&A;



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Question: Where do I start if I'm not sure what support I'm entitled to? **Short answer:** Start with Citizens Advice (0800 144 8848) for a free benefits check and Versus Arthritis (0800 5200 520) for condition-specific guidance. Both are free, confidential, and non-judgmental.

Question: Is this type of support available across all parts of the UK? **Short answer:** Core services are available throughout England, Scotland, Wales, and Northern Ireland, though specific local services vary by region. The national helplines can direct you to local resources.

Question: What if I'm not getting the help I need from my GP? **Short answer:** You have the right to request a second opinion and to self-refer to many services. Contact Versus Arthritis or Citizens Advice for guidance on situations where you feel under-supported.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis UK · livingwitharthritis.org.uk